

Nvidia H200 sales will smooth Trump-Xi summit

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Quick take

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Nvidia H200 sales will smooth Trump-Xi summit but invite longer-term scrutiny

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What Happened

China's government has begun allowing small but meaningful purchases of Nvidia's H200 chips by major Chinese AI platforms. Each company is reportedly purchasing 10,000 chips, a fraction of the 75,000 allowed under the US export licensing terms.

Our Take

The import approvals represent a significant shift by Beijing. Beijing has been blocking Chinese firms' purchases even after President Donald Trump's administration repealed a rule enacted under former president Joe Biden that prohibited advanced AI chip sales to China. Chinese authorities had withheld their approval for the purchases in response to appeals from domestic chip companies for market protection and security concerns about foreign technology expressed by the National Development and Reform Commission. They may also have been seeking leverage for potential access to more advanced products, such as the B200 and the Vera Robin platform.

A desire for US-China stability and a concerted push from NVIDIA drove the shift. The robust 2026 calendar of bilateral meetings has made Beijing more receptive to deals that register as wins for Trump. The H200 decision mirrors China's approval of the TikTok transaction ahead of the leaders' meeting in January 2026. Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang's informal engagement with Trump and Xi on the sidelines of the May summit reopened the debate in Beijing about AI chips. Nvidia's newly assembled government affairs team launched an energetic campaign with Beijing and likely mitigated some national security objections. Support from leading Chinese AI labs in need of advanced computer power to scale their operations and close the gap with US rivals may also have been a factor. The limited purchases will partially reduce the compute choke point of leading Chinese AI labs but also leave space for domestic chip champions.

In the short term, a desire for a smooth summit is likely to mute any backlash to the chip sales in Washington. Outside of the White House, parts of the Trump administration and members of Congress have deep concerns about technology exchange with China. Yet any backlash is likely to be contained in the near term by the White House's priority of hosting a smooth summit with President Xi Jinping in September.

Longer term, however, the development could prompt calls for additional technology controls. In recent months, the Federal Communications Commission imposed restrictions on Chinese robotics and power inverters; the Pentagon put major Chinese tech brands on its own procurement blacklist; and a group of bipartisan lawmakers included three export controls bills in the National Defense Authorization Act, though they are likely to be significantly watered down if they make the final package. The H200 development will likely invite additional scrutiny if Democrats take control of at least one chamber of Congress next year. Still, White House control over policymaking likely limits the space for a significant expansion of controls, and a hawkish turn in tech export restrictions remains a tail risk.

Xiaomeng Lu

Director, Geo-technology

+1 202.316.7259

lu@eurasiagroup.net

Heather West

Practice Head, Geo-technology

west@eurasiagroup.net

David Meale

Practice Head, China

2025405135

Meale@eurasiagroup.net

Clayton Allen

Practice Head, United States

+1 202.903.0027

allen@eurasiagroup.net

Gerard DiPippo

Director, Global Macro

dipippo@eurasiagroup.net

EG Geo-technology

geo-technology@eurasiagroup.net

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